

of time, and a handful of determination, I fabricated what would be my first successful model bridge. About two feet in length and weighing less than a pair of scissors, it was able to support 10 pounds of weight. Encouraged, I continued my research by analyzing pictures of existing bridges, hoping to unravel any hint or clue that might aid in my investigation.

Finally, after I had drawn several rough drafts by hand, I decided to try again, this time relying not on luck but on intuition. Calling together everything that I knew, I combined tension-efficient bars with compression-efficient tubes; with this final culmination of research, I created the ultimate bridge, one that had no veritable excuse to collapse while under my guidance. I decided it was time for judgment. Uploading the file onto the West Point server, I sat back and waited while the contest experts analyzed the structure. I closed my eyes, allowing myself a short nap of relaxation and of satisfaction. At last, I woke up – almost immediately I sat up in my chair – my mind raced as my eyes read, “*Unofficial Results: 1st of 468 registered teams in Zone 4, Pacific States.*” Two months later, I emerged as a semifinalist by ranking in the top 25 teams nationwide. After that point I gained the necessary confidence in my engineering intuition to fuel my new fascination.

I often ask myself why I did not discover engineering earlier in my life. But as I reflect, I realize that I have always been inherently inquisitive about the nature of machines. By examining or disassembling devices to figure out how they work, I learned to fix everything from broken bandsaws in woodshop to loose ball bearings in nunchucks from martial arts.

I can no longer remember how my mind used to work, but I know that in one way or another I have progressed from a state of carefree ennui to one of enlightened fervor. No longer can I glance at a building and not think about its architecture, design, and construction techniques; no longer can I cross a bridge and not comprehend its support system. My mind seems to be ahead of my body: I have gained the understanding, but I require more experience; I have learned about bridges, but I have not yet built ^{or} real one. Until I do, I remain in the same state as that Styrofoam dart that first awakened my curiosity: patiently waiting for an educational boost towards potential.